

How are we to live?

Ages 8-11

*Evidence-based pointers on living well —
each with its study design, its effect size, and its honest
weakness.*

Trust but verify

Before any of the health pages, one rule for the whole site: **you are allowed to check.**

Grown-ups, adverts and posters will tell you lots of things about your health. Some are true, some are half-true, and some were written by a company that wants your money. The trick is not to believe everyone, and not to believe *no one* either — it is to ask a simple question: *how do you know that?*

Trust but verify (cont.)

Every page here tries to answer that question. It shows where each fact came from, how sure we are, and what is still shaky about it. If a page ever just tells you what to think without showing its homework, it has failed. **Knowing how to check is a kind of power** — it means nobody gets to decide the truth for you.

Smoking kills, stopping helps

Almost nothing you do at your age is likely to make you ill or hurt you badly — and when a child your age does get seriously ill, it is nearly always something nobody chose, like a rare illness or an accident. Smoking is not on that list yet. It is a **slow** danger, not a fast one.

So why talk about it now? Because of one strange fact: **almost everyone who ends up smoking for life started when they were young — around your age or a little older.** The people who sell cigarettes and vapes know this. That is why the danger is worth knowing about early, even though it feels far away.

Smoking kills, stopping helps (cont.)

Here is the good news, and it is the whole point: with smoking, **not starting fixes everything.** You do not have to be strong or give anything up. If you never start, the entire problem simply never happens to you. It is one of the very few big health choices where doing *nothing* is the winning move.

Alcohol: no safe dose

You are too young to drink, so this page is not really about tonight — it is about one honest, slightly boring fact worth knowing early.

Here it is: **alcohol is never actually good for your body.** Not in a small amount, not in a large one. You will hear people say things like "a glass of wine is good for your heart" — that turned out to be a mistake in how the old studies were done. There is no amount that *helps*.

Alcohol: no safe dose (cont.)

That does not mean a single drink will badly hurt an adult — usually it won't. It just means there is no magic safe level where alcohol switches from good to bad, because it was never on the good side to begin with.

Gambling: designed so you lose

This one is not really about luck — it is about **maths**, and once you see the maths you cannot un-see it.

A gambling game is built so that, on average, the people playing it lose and the company running it wins. That is not bad luck or a mean streak; it is a rule the company **decided in advance and wrote down**. They keep a small slice of everything that gets bet. You might win sometimes — that is what keeps it exciting — but play long enough and the slice always wins.

Gambling: designed so you lose (cont.)

At your age the version to watch for is on a screen: games where you pay (or watch an advert) to open a "mystery box" or spin for a prize. They are training wheels for exactly this feeling. Knowing the trick — *the game was built so the maker comes out ahead* — is the whole defence. You do not have to be strong; you just have to see it.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much.

Carrying a lot of extra body fat is genuinely bad for you. As you get older it makes serious illnesses — diabetes, heart disease, even some cancers — much more likely. That is not about how you look; it is about what the extra fat does inside your body.

Here is the hard part, and the reason grown-ups make such a fuss about it early: **once your body gets used to carrying extra weight, it fights to keep it.** Losing it later and staying that way turns out to be really difficult for almost everyone. So by far the easiest time to deal with it is to *not get there in the first place.*

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much. (cont.)

The good news is that this is much less about willpower than it sounds. **You eat more when more food is easy to reach.** If there is a bowl of crisps next to you, you eat crisps; if there is a bowl of apples, you eat apples. And you eat more when you are simply *given* more — a bigger plate or a bigger packet makes almost everyone eat more without noticing. So the trick is not fighting yourself at the table — it is what ends up in the cupboard, and how much lands on the plate. That is what "eat food, mostly plants, not too much" is really about.

Move more, sit less

This is the cheerful one. You do not need a gym, and you do not need to hit any special number.

Here is the real finding, and it is good news: the **biggest** health boost from moving comes simply from *not being one of the people who barely moves at all*. Going from almost-no-movement to some-movement is where nearly all the benefit is. After that, more is a nice bonus, not a rule.

So whatever gets you off the sofa counts — running around, cycling, a sport, dancing, walking the dog. Getting up and moving *at all* is the win.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

And the best bit for right now: moving your body actually makes you feel good *today* — a better mood, a clearer head, less grumpiness. You don't have to wait fifty years to get something out of it.

Sleep like it matters

Sleep is not really about living longer — it is about **how you feel tomorrow**. After a good night you handle a hard day better: your mood is steadier, you can concentrate, things that would normally annoy you bounce off. After a bad night, everything feels harder, and that is not you being weak — it is just a tired brain.

So the honest reason to protect your sleep is not fear. It is that sleep is the cheapest, most reliable way to make tomorrow go better. It works in days, not decades — you can feel the difference this week.

Slip, slop, slap

Slip on a shirt, **slop** on sunscreen, **slap** on a hat. Three little actions, one for each word — that is the whole thing, and it is a really *good* piece of advice.

Why is it good? Because it does not threaten you or blame you. It just tells you three easy things to do. And unlike a lot of health advice, this one was actually tested properly in a real experiment, and it worked: people who used sunscreen regularly got less skin cancer later on.

The nice part is how little effort it takes — a shirt, some sunscreen, a hat, and staying in the shade when the sun is strong. Small actions, real protection.

Change the rules, not just yourself

Every page here says the same quiet thing: living well is less about being strong than about the world around you being set up to help. Here is the biggest version of that — **the world around you is built by people's decisions, and it can be built to make health easy or hard.**

Whether the air indoors is clean, whether there are safe paths to walk and cycle on, whether the cheap and easy food is the healthy kind — none of that is fixed by nature. People decided it, through rules and choices, and people can decide it differently.

Change the rules, not just yourself (cont.)

That is the hopeful part: it is not set in stone, and one day it will partly be up to **you**. When you are older you get a vote and a voice, and using them to help build a healthier world is one of the most powerful things you can do — for yourself and for everyone else.

Trust, but verify.

Full evidence — with the study designs, the effect sizes, and the honest weaknesses — is on the site.

Information is power.